or Western civilisation. This concept may be a bit nebulous, as was the ‘Gandhian socialism’ of Deen Dayal Upadhyaya that the BJP had briefly adopted in the 1980s. It is, however, rooted in the civilisational notion of India as a Hindu power that is steeped in ‘parampara’, or tradition. This is an India wielding the soft power of ancient Hindu practices, acting as a swing state—probably in the sense that Samuel Huntington meant it when he wrote *The Clash of Civilizations*. Huntington’s thesis, first fleshed out as an article in 1993, basically argued that the praxis of local politics would shift to the ‘politics of ethnicity’, while that of global politics would shift to the ‘politics of civilizations’. In other words, ‘cultural entities’ would become the central dividing axes of power, locally and internationally: Sinic (Chinese), Islamic, Japanese, Orthodox (Russia), Western (Europe, North America, Australia, New Zealand), Latin American, African and Hindu (India).[7] While this idea was severely critiqued for simplifying the complexity of international relations—such as the huge differences among Islamic states— its central thesis of essentialist ‘cultural’ norms acting as a powerful guiding force for states willing to use them is undeniable.

Yogi Adityanath’s assertion on Diwali 2020 that the government-organised ritual lighting of over 606,569 lamps by the banks of the Sarayu river in Ayodhya was meant to connect ‘Bharatvanshis’ (descendants of Bharat), whatever their ‘mat-mazhab’ (views-religion), to the ‘ideals of Sri Ram’ should be seen in this context.[8] At one level, it was simply a spectacle for the faithful—going up to 941,551 lamps on Diwali in 2021. For five years in a row, the Uttar Pradesh government’s department of tourism even received a certificate from representatives of the Guinness Book of World Records for the lamp-lighting, which was monitored through drone-mounted cameras.[9] Yogi Adityanath framed Ayodhya’s Deep Mahotsav (Great Festival of Lamps) as a ‘symbol of public faith in our culture getting stronger’ and dedicated the Guinness record to ‘all Ram-Bhakts’.[10] Tellingly, the UP chief minister said that it was his job to take such a celebration to the world, so it would not only help ‘brand’ Ayodhya but also take ‘Sri Ram’s blessings’ to the people of the world.[11] Statements like these merged seamlessly with his